

The Autonomy Assumption: Learning That Some People Want Closer Management

Practice date: 2026-10-02. Behavioral theme: receiving critical feedback that changed how you lead.

The story

Situation. "Early in my time leading a larger org, my manager gave me direct feedback: I intervene too slowly. My default was to give people room — let them run, even let them fail, then help them recover. His point was that for some people, that reads as me not paying attention, not as empowerment. Since that is not my style, it was initially difficult for me to hear."

Task. "This was specifically about one of my managers, who wanted me looking into their daily work — they felt that otherwise I wasn't paying attention. My instinct was that nobody wants to be micromanaged. The feedback forced me to see that 'everyone wants autonomy' was my assumption, not a read of the person. The feedback I took away: don't assume everyone likes autonomy; sometimes they like closer management."

Action. "Two changes. First, with that group and that person specifically, I stopped guessing and asked: what level of involvement do you want — is this too much, too little? — and I kept checking the calibration itself. Second, and this is what stuck: I started asking every new team member upfront what their preferred style is, because teams keep changing and you can't assume. I also set an explicit alignment cadence beyond the usual weekly 1:1s and quarterly checks — a recurring 'are we still calibrated' conversation."

Result. "The change I saw was in them and in me. They started valuing my opinion more — because I'd taken feedback well, they felt free to say whatever they wanted. They stopped routing around me to my skip-level and started bringing things to me directly. And I saw it in productivity: once I started giving more direct feedback, they loosened up and moved faster."

Interview signal

Senior loops probe coachability with one question: did the feedback actually change a behavior, durably? The durable change here isn't "I micromanage now" — it's "I ask every new team member their preferred style upfront and I re-check calibration on a cadence." That's a mechanism, not a reflection. Expect the follow-up: "Tell me about a second piece of feedback you acted on" — have one ready; it tests whether the loop is a habit or a one-off.

Key takeaways

- Lead with the honest first reaction ("it was initially difficult — that's not my style"). Owning the resistance is what makes the change credible.

- The tension is the story's strength: you still believe autonomy and a safe space to fail grow people. What changed is you stopped assuming autonomy is what everyone wants on day one. Now you ask, you calibrate, and you earn the right to give rope.
- The payoff to name: people bringing you problems directly instead of routing to your skip-level — that's the trust metric for a senior leader.